**EUROPEAN COUNCIL**

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| Subject: | Meeting of the EUROPEAN COUNCIL held on 20 and 21 March 2014 |

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## 1. Exchange of views with the President of the European Parliament

The President of the European Parliament was heard by the European Council.

## 2. Adoption of the agenda

The European Council adopted its agenda (doc. EUCO 8/14).

## 3. Growth, Competitiveness and Jobs

The European Council concluded the first phase of the 2014 European Semester and assessed the implementation of the Europe 2020 strategy in view of its review scheduled for 2015.

The European Council underlined the importance of formally adopting the Single Resolution Mechanism Regulation before the end of the current legislature.

The European Council discussed issues related to the taxation of savings income. In the light of the European Council's discussion on the topic, the Directive on taxation of savings income will be adopted by the Council at its next March 2014 meeting.

The European Council held a debate on industrial competitiveness, underlining the need for a strong and competitive industrial base, in terms of both production and investment. It looked at ways to achieve this and agreed to come back to these issues in the context of the Europe 2020 strategy review in 2015.

The European Council held a first debate on a new EU policy framework for climate and energy in the period 2020 to 2030. It agreed on a set of principles on which the framework should be based and established a roadmap for further work. It agreed to take stock of progress made at its meeting in June, based inter alia on consultations with Member States, with a view to taking a final decision on the new policy framework as quickly as possible and no later than October 2014. The European Council asked its President and the European Commission to take the necessary steps to prepare this decision.

In the area of energy, the European Council called for intensified efforts to reduce Europe's high gas energy dependency rates. It called on the Commission to conduct an in-depth study of EU energy security and to present by June 2014 a comprehensive plan for the reduction of EU energy dependence. In addition, the European Council requested to speed up action to complete the internal energy market by 2014 and to develop interconnections to end the isolation of Member States from European gas and electricity networks by 2015. It identified also measures aiming at moderating the energy costs borne by energy end-users and discussed the issue of energy prices.

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The European Council welcomed the resumption of fully fledged settlement negotiations based on the 11 February Joint Declaration with the aim to reunite Cyprus.

## 4. External Relations

The European Council held an in-depth discussion on the situation in Ukraine and agreed a number of concrete measures to support Ukraine. The European Council strongly condemned the annexation of Crimea and Sevastopol to the Russian Federation. It decided on an extension of the visa ban and asset freeze and cancelled the next EU-Russia Summit.

Ahead of the 4th EU-Africa Summit, the European Council exchanged views on EU-Africa relations, with a particular focus on peace and security.

## 5. Approval of the conclusions

The European Council approved its conclusions, setting out the outcome of its discussions (doc. EUCO 7/14).

**6. Adoption of the Minutes of the European Council on 19 and 20 December 2013**

The European Council adopted the minutes of its meetings held on 19 and 20 December 2013 as set out in doc. EUCO 218/13.

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*In the margins of the meeting, the EU and its Member States signed the political provisions of the Association Agreement with Ukraine.*

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